> "The food has to be in a form that is moist, so that it sticks together and does not float around, as surface tension is a primary force acting there. For instance, you cannot have dry basmati rice, as it will explode and go everywhere. That's a challenge"



Hyderabad. It was the most beautiful sight I have ever seen. It still gives me goosebumps describing it, the pictures and videos just don't do it justice.

Q. Looking down on Earth and seeing all the continents, rivers and seas, did you turn philosophical?

You are referring to what astronauts call the overview effect. I don't know what others felt but, for me, there was a shift in perspective. From space, you cannot make out where the different countries or divisions are, in Africa or Europe or elsewhere. The second thing is that the size and scale of Earth make us humans look insignificant. And the third thing is that everything you know, everyone you know, the entire history of humankind, all happened here and you are looking at it from the outside. So, you begin to understand things differently.

Q. How is that?

Like I said before, the biggest realisation is the insignificance of what we do on Earth. Sometimes, our ego takes over, and we become quite big in our heads. I recalled what astronomer Carl Sagan wrote—that everyone you know, every monarch, emperor, ruler, all the big people—lived on this small pale blue dot. They've been there, they've done everything, and they've gone—and the rest of the universe doesn't even know about it. So, yes, that was an exceptionally powerful feeling.

Q. Did it make you more spiritual or religious?

Being spiritual and being religious are two different things. I am spiritual and do try to do some meditation on the ground because I feel it is important. But I am not good at it. I find it extremely difficult to sit in one place for long without thoughts coming into my mind. In space, when we had time, I'd sit beside the window and look down at Earth. I could sit for hours, meditating, with nothing coming to my mind—no thoughts, no worries, no questions. You just observe what is happening and don't need anything. It is meditation in a way that's so easy. Time ceases. You are just in that moment. I think it is also because of the uniqueness of Earth. Because every time you orbit it, even though it's the same planet and the same space station, it's a different time of the day—Earth is rotating, the angle of the sun is different and so you never see the same thing twice.



> "You have to learn how to do things. You cannot have a shower because falling water is difficult to catch. You have special hygiene towels instead, which are lined with soap and everything else you use. Basically, it is a wet bath"

Q. After her first trip to space, Kalpana Chawla told me that just before she'd go to sleep, she couldn't feel her body because of weightlessness but could feel the weight of her thoughts. Did you have a similar experience?

No, I am a good sleeper. I slept well for most of my trip except for the first few days at the space station. And that was because, in space, your spine starts elongating since there is no load on it unlike on Earth. That causes back pain and it bothered me for a couple of nights. After that, I was sleeping peacefully.